

Emeka's 3rd-Grade Year — *Author, Not Audience*

A Spark Builders curriculum, built for Emeka

For: Emeka (age 8, entering 3rd grade, Fall 2026) · Built by: Dad / Coach Lamont Engine 1 — daily skills: her app, [emeka-grades.vercel.app](#) · Engine 2 — real builds: the Spark loop

Where Emeka really is (from her actual 2nd-grade report card)

Built from her **real** report card — P.S. 182, Grade 2, 2025-26. A plan only works if it starts from the truth, so here's the honest, loving picture. (NYC scale: **4** = exceeds · **3** = on grade level · **2** = approaching/below · **1** = well below.)

Her superpowers — the engine of everything:

- **Effort, persistence, organization, asking for help** — all **3s**. This is the single best predictor of future success, and it's *already hers*.
- **Social-Emotional** = **3**, and a confident talker — "expresses ideas with clarity" = **3**.
- **Shines in the arts & movement** — Music **4**, PE **4**, Visual Art **3**.
- Inside reading, her **decoding & fluency** = **3** — she sounds out and reads smoothly.
- Inside math, she **understands the concepts** = **3** — the ideas are there.

Where she's below grade level right now — this is the work, and it's very fixable:

Subject (current grade)	The gap inside it	What her teacher said to do
Reading = 2	Decoding is fine; comprehension is the gap (grade-level texts 2, text details 2)	Practice reading + retelling ; sight-word flash cards ; iReady reading daily
Writing = 2	Tasks, details, revising, mechanics all 2	Practice 3-4 sentences on a topic; neat handwriting; capitals & punctuation
Math = 2 (“approaching grade level”)	Concepts good; precision/accuracy & explaining are the gap	Master +/- within 20 ; memorize facts ; ask “What’s happening? What do you know? What are you trying to figure out?”; iReady math daily
ELA, Science, Social Studies = 2	Core academics sit at grade-approaching	Same foundations carry over

The straight talk: Emeka doesn't need *harder* work — she needs **steady, foundational reps** to climb to grade level, aimed at the exact things her teacher named. And she already has the rarest ingredient: **she tries hard and doesn't quit**. We point that effort at *reading-to-understand, writing clearly, and math facts* — and she climbs. This plan makes those reps feel like **building, not drilling**, so she stays hungry.

(She was G&T-eligible from her early grades — proof the ceiling is real. This year is about rebuilding the floor under it.)

Good news: the app you built (`emeka-grades`) already targets these exact gaps — Reading has a **retell** step, Writing checks **detail + mechanics**, and Math uses the teacher's *very* scaffold: "what's happening / what do you know / what are you trying to find." Pair it with the school's **iReady** (the teacher asked for daily iReady reading + math) and you've got her covered.

The one rule that runs the whole year: Emeka is the **author**, not the audience. She notices the problem, she decides what to make, she directs it. You're the coach who drives — never the one who decides.

Her two problem-solving superpowers (she learns *both* this year)

This is the heart of your question — Spark teaches a kid to handle a problem on **both sides** of the moment it appears:

- 🔭 **See it coming — Foresight.** Spot the **smoke before the fire** and build a small ***early stop** so the problem never grows up. "Fix what's about to break."***
- 🛠️ **Fix it when she sees it — Respond.** A problem is already here — find the **real gap** under it and build the fix. "*Fix what's broken.*"

The Spark sequence (and your instinct) match: do **Foresight first, Respond as the capstone**. So this year she runs the loop 4 times — **two as Foresight, two as Respond** — and by Demo Day she can do both: get ready before the problem *and* solve it when it lands.

The two engines (run both, every week)

	Engine 1 — Daily Reps	Engine 2 — Build Expeditions
What	iReady (reading + math — the teacher's daily ask) + 15-20 min on emeka-grades	One real project every ~4-6 weeks using the Spark 8-session loop
Job	Foundations & report-card standards — the "scales"	Meaning & agency — the "song"

	Engine 1 — Daily Reps	Engine 2 — Build Expeditions
Who drives	Emeka, solo (you check progress)	Emeka directs, you drive the typing
Proof	iReady minutes + app streak/progress screen	A live thing she gave to a real person

Engine 1 climbs the grades (and is exactly what her teacher asked for). Engine 2 keeps the **fire** — so the foundational reps feel like building toward something she cares about, not punishment. Most kids get neither consistently. Emeka gets both.

Part A — The academic targets (foundations → grade level)

The plan is to **secure her 2nd-grade foundations first** (the things her report card flagged), then climb into the 3rd-grade Common Core standards. The ★ **PRIORITY / FOUNDATION** bullets are the exact things her teacher said to work on — those come *before* the stretch goals. Each has a home in her app.

Math — "facts first, then reasoning"

- ★ **FOUNDATION FIRST** — +/- within 20 to automatic recall. Memorize the facts (flash cards, app Fast Facts, Math Sprint). *This is the teacher's #1 ask — secure it before multiplication.*
- ★ **PRIORITY — precision & explaining:** show the work, *check* the answer, and say *how* you solved it. Use the teacher's exact scaffold every time: "What's happening? What do you know? What are you trying to figure out?" (it's built into the app's word problems).
 - Then build into 3rd grade: multiplication & division within 100 (start the $\times 2/\times 5/\times 10$ families), and **fractions** (halves, thirds, fourths; equal shares).
 - Area & perimeter, telling time, simple bar/picture graphs — as she's ready.
 - App home: Math + Daily + Games · plus iReady math daily.

Reading — "from reading the words to understanding them"

Her **decoding & fluency are strong (3)** — the gap is **comprehension (2)**. The whole focus is *understanding and remembering*, not sounding-out.

- ★ **FOUNDATION — retell every time:** after each read, she **retells** it — characters, setting, problem/solution (her teacher's exact target). Then: "what was the main idea? how do you know?"
- ★ **PRIORITY — sight words:** a few minutes of **sight-word flash cards** (teacher's ask) to free up her brain for meaning.
- Build into 3rd grade: main idea + key details, **inference** ("show me the words"), the

lesson/moral of a story, character feelings.

- **App home:** Reading (tap-word read-aloud + retell step) · **plus iReady reading daily.**
- **Off-app target:** a **20-minute read** + a one-sentence "what was the lesson?" out loud.

Writing — "from neat sentences to a paragraph"

Everything in writing is at **2** — so we build from the sentence up.

- ★ **FOUNDATION** — **3-4 sentences on a topic, written neatly** (teacher's exact ask): good letter size & spacing, **capitals at the start, punctuation at the end.**

- ★ **PRIORITY** — **detail + revising:** one "add a detail" pass and one "fix the capitals/punctuation" pass on every draft. The app auto-checks both.

- **Build into 3rd grade:** a **full paragraph** (topic → detail → detail → closing), then **dialogue** with quotation marks, and opinion/narrative pieces.

- **App home:** Writing (enforces min-sentences + mechanics).
- **App home:** Writing (it enforces min-sentences/min-words per grade).

The 4th strand — Thinking & Making (this is the Spark part)

Not on a report card, but the reason for the whole year:

- **Notice on purpose** (observation), **ask why, what-if, how-do-you-know**, ****what-would-change-my-mind**** — the 5-rung Thinking Ladder.
- Turning a noticing into a **build**, giving it to a real person, and **improving it from real use.**

Part B — The weekly rhythm

A repeatable week. Same shape every time; only the content changes.

Day	Engine 1 (daily reps, ~15–20 min)	Engine 2 (the build)
Mon	Math (app Math) + 20-min read	<i>Spark session</i> (see the loop below)
Tue	Reading (app Reading) + 20-min read	—
Wed	Writing (app Writing) + 20-min read	<i>Spark session</i>
Thu	Math + Daily mix + 20-min read	—
Fri	Games (fun reps) + "what was the lesson?"	Show-and-tell / log the week
Weekend	One free build, draw, or read-aloud together	rest / family pillar

Two non-negotiables (the fire):

1. **Callback** — every Spark session *starts* by making her retrieve last time's thinking.
2. **Open loop** — every Spark session *ends* with one real question she carries out the door.

Part C — The build expeditions (both methods, term by term)

Each expedition is **one real problem** → **one live tool she gives someone**, run across 8 short sessions. She'll do **4 across the year**, one per Pillar — **two in Foresight mode**, **two in Respond mode** — and each one *secretly* drills the academic skills from Part A. That's the trick.

The two loops (same rhythm, different starting question)

Both run on the same weekly rhythm; they only differ in *where the problem comes from*.

#	 FORESIGHT loop (<i>see it coming</i>)	 RESPOND loop (<i>fix what's here</i>)
1	Map it — how does this thing normally work?	Notice — a real problem she spotted
2	Find the weak spot — where could it go wrong?	Listen — real quotes from the person who has it
3	Smoke before fire — what's the <i>early signal</i> ?	Find the Gap — the real problem under the obvious one
4	Play the tape forward — "if nobody acts, then...?"	Smallest Thing — first tiny version, critiqued
5	Smallest early stop — the tiniest thing that prevents it	Light It Up — a live tool, given to a real person
6	Build the stop — make the early-warning / helper live	Improve — a better v2 + proof it helped
7	Break your own fix — try to make it fail, then patch it	Second Star — a new or deeper build
8	Demo Day — shows what she caught <i>before</i> it broke	Demo Day — shows what she built + learned

Kid-language cheat: Foresight = "*smell the smoke and unplug it before there's a fire.*" Respond = "*the spill already happened — clean it up and stop it next time.*" Same noticing, different timing.

Term 1 (Fall) — **FORESIGHT** · Pillar: **YOURSELF** · Academic focus: **Math-fact fluency (+/- within 20) + neat 3–4 sentences**

Sample build: "*My Math-Fact Smoke Detector*" — she figures out **which fact she's about to forget** (the early signal), then builds a tiny daily early-warning practice that catches it *before* the test, not after a bad grade. (*This is literally her teacher's #1 ask, turned into her own project.*)

- **Play the tape:** "If I don't catch this fact, what happens on the quiz?"
- **Drills:** +/- facts to automatic recall; she writes **3-4 neat sentences** explaining her system.
- **Real person:** herself (the easiest first "person" to practice Foresight on).

Term 2 (Winter) — 🦋 FORESIGHT • Pillar: HOME • Academic focus: Fair shares (intro fractions) + retelling

Sample build: "Before-It's-a-Fight Fair Shares" — she spots where an **unfair split** is *about* to cause an **argument** at home (snacks, chores, screen time) and builds a simple **equal-shares / halves & fourths** helper that prevents the fight before it starts.

- **Smoke before fire:** the look on a sibling's face *before* the "that's not fair!"
- **Drills:** equal shares, halves/thirds/fourths, "is this fair?" reasoning — explained out loud.
- **Real person:** the family. Proof = the argument that *never happened*.

Term 3 (Spring) — 🦋 RESPOND • Pillar: COMMUNITY • Academic focus: Reading for main idea + opinion writing

Sample build: "One Thing I'd Fix" — a problem that's **already here:** she interviews a neighbor/classmate, finds the real gap, and writes a short **opinion piece** (claim + reasons) or a tiny info page that helps.

- **Drills:** main idea, inference, **opinion writing** with reasons and evidence.
- **Real person:** someone outside the family — the outward turn.

Term 4 (Summer/End) — 🦋 RESPOND (capstone) • Pillar: WORLD • Academic focus: Research reading + narrative writing

Sample build: "Something I Wonder About" — she picks a real-world thing she cares about, reads two sources, and makes a little story or explainer that **teaches someone else** how to handle it.

- **Capstone twist:** she names whether her project is *Foresight or Respond* — and why. That naming *is* the proof she learned both.
- **Drills:** compare two texts, nonfiction features, **narrative** with dialogue.
- **Real person:** she *teaches it* to someone — the deepest test of understanding.

Part D — How we'll know it's working

Signal	Where to see it
Grades climbing 2 → 3	School report card (Reading, Writing, Math especially)
iReady levels rising	iReady reading + math dashboards
Math facts automatic	App streak + timed Games ; no finger-counting
Real reading comprehension	She can retell a book + say the lesson unprompted

Signal	Where to see it
Writing grows	3-4 neat sentences → a real paragraph; capitals & punctuation stick
The Spark part	She finishes & gives away 4 real builds this year

The Expedition Log: a real paper notebook. One line after every Spark session — *the problem I noticed, the realest thing they said, the smartest thing I thought*. By hand. This is the keepsake.

Coach's one job (restated, for you)

Run the rhythm. Protect the seed — **she decides**. Never let a session end without a question she carries out the door. Do that, and you haven't taught Emeka to do 3rd grade — you've taught her to **keep thinking, and to face outward**. That's the star that doesn't go out.

Quick-start (this week)

1. Open **emeka-grades.vercel.app** and run the **diagnostic** — let it place her honestly (likely

Grade 2 foundations to start; it moves her up as she masters skills). Don't force a grade.

1. Log into **iReady** (reading + math) — the teacher asked for daily; even 15 min counts.
 2. Start the 20-min nightly read tonight; end with a **retell** + "*what was the lesson?*"
 3. Make a set of +/- **flash cards** and a few **sight-word cards** — 5 minutes a day.
 4. Run **Spark Session 1** Monday: she finds one real "stuck moment" to build for.
 5. Get her a notebook. Title page: "**Emeka's Expedition Log**."
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Privacy: first name + age only. Her last name, school, and records stay in Dad's private files — never in this document or repo.